CHAPTER 2

THE MEETING

27 April 2024, 12:00pm

It suddenly strikes me that it is weird all three of them are going to be there. Stokes, McCullum *and* Key?

I am on the tram, on the way to what I think is a contract appraisal. I'm not driving because I'm going to see Burnley play away at Manchester United later that afternoon. I'm excited to not only be going to the game but to catch up with my mates after being on tour for a couple of months. It's not an unusual Saturday afternoon in waiting. I've had many like it before. Appraisal. Yes, I agree, wish we'd done a bit better in India, especially after winning that first Test. Yes, thank you, me too, I'm pretty happy with how I bowled. Yes, ready to go this summer, can't wait. See you then. Watch Burnley play with Gaz and Dave. A few drinks. Home. Same as usual. That's the plan.

We are meeting at the Dakota Hotel in Manchester. It is midday so it's quiet in there, an erring sense of a busy space vacated. A few staff usher bits to and from corners of the lobby with the morning rush now done. It's a trendy hotel, intentionally dimly lit for privacy, and the three of them are waiting in the corner at the end of the bar, lights low, caps over their faces.

As I walk towards them, it hits me cold. This isn't a team appraisal, is it? With each footstep towards the far side of the bar, each of their distinct silhouettes coming into view, the tram journey just gone is suddenly like a blissful past life, the outdoor sun sucked into a horizonless neon red darkness. They are all wearing sympathetic expressions on their faces when I reach them – half the kind you get when a relative has died and half the kind of someone who is worried you're going to go for them. They sit there,